

TV SOAPS

Coming into Their Prime

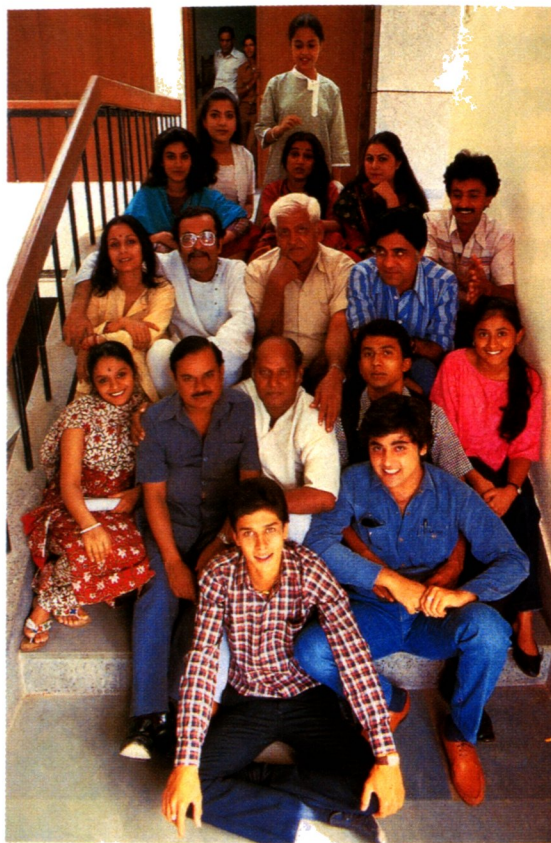
Remember the time when people switched on their television to watch the capers of carrot-crunching detective Karamchand played by whatshisname with a mole on his nose? And the main attraction of *Khandaan* were the intrigues of Ketki, played by whosthatgirl with a sexy pout? Or that loud-mouthed protagonist of *Nukkad*—whose real name no one bothered to find out. But not any longer. Now, at 9 p.m., people tune in to see Pankaj Kapoor, not Karamchand, playing Phatichar. While the saucy Ketki after numerous avatars is today recognised as Neena Gupta. And Guru, now identified as the hazel-eyed Dilip Dhawan, has emerged as the small screen's undisputed guru. The host of artistes who have broken out of the strait-jacket of their stellar roles have overcome the “zip, zap, zoom stardom” of prime time television, where popularity lasts only as long as the serial, and proved beyond doubt that they are not one-serial wonders. Most already have over half-a-dozen popular shows to their credit. And today they are sought after by producers and directors.

By W.P.S. Skhu, October 31, 1991, INDIA TODAY

Kumkum. The company's turnover in 2000-01 was Rs 110 crore, while in 2006-07 it hit Rs 318 crore when Ekta Kapoor alone was worth more than Rs 500 crore. While *Kyunki...* took time to generate TRPs with its first episode—only 1.7, *Kahaani...* opened with a TRP of 6.9. This phenomena didn't apply only to Star Plus. Sony TV too entered with *Kkusum*, the story of a middle-class girl who marries into a rich family, with a TRP of 3.6 in 2001.

Soon Tulsi and Parvati became icons. While Tulsi became the ideal bahu, the scheming villains too shot to fame. Tailors started copying Komolika's blouses and beauty parlours started promoting Sudha Chandran's vertical bindis from *Kahiin Kissi Roz*. Even the male characters became the stuff of legend. When Amar Upadhyay as Mihir, the original hero of *Kyunki...* was killed, women took to the streets shouting slogans. Kapoor had no choice but to resurrect his character, and, yes, TRPs zoomed. “*Kyunki...* struck a chord

20 m
watched *Kyunki...*
in Delhi, Kolkata,
and Mumbai
in November
2006-07



FAMILY TIES: *Hum Log*, India's first tv soap

because of its everyday story of saas and bahu. But what it has been reduced to is unreal,” says Mandira Bedi, who played villain for a year, explaining that the problem these shows face is that they just don't know when to stop.

The same audience that understands Tulsi's *Mother India*-inspired decision to kill her son, had made success stories out of serials like *Hum Log*, *Buniyaad* and *Nukkad* 25 years ago. These shows came at a time when television began portraying the pathos of the middle-class, which hadn't yet learnt the meaning of disposable income. Much has changed since the days of Haveliram and Lajoji, but the audience's obsession with vindicated women and philandering husbands remains. “There was no TRP system then but we would hear that streets were deserted when *Buniyaad* was on air,” says

Alok Nath, who played Haveliram. While Nath, who played the lead in *Hum Log*, was paid Rs 2,500 per episode, top actors now get over Rs 50,000 for a day's shoot. But actors believe change is round the corner. TRPs that clocked 11 at one time, have dipped to 5-6. Many soap factory products have been rejected recently. Another Tulsi is needed for Project Revival, and fast. ■